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IDEAL Model

A systematic approach to problem solving

$I \rightarrow D \rightarrow E \rightarrow A \rightarrow L$

Identify the Problem

Define the Goals

Explore Possible Solutions

Act on the Best Solution

Look Back and Learn

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What is the IDEAL Model?

IDEAL is a step-by-step problem-solving model.

It helps us move from a problem to a practical solution.

It encourages clear thinking instead of guessing or jumping to a solution.

The five stages are: Identify → Define → Explore → Act → Look Back.

I – Identify the Problem

First, understand what the actual problem is.

Clearly identify what is wrong or what needs to be improved.

Collect relevant information and avoid assumptions.

Ask: What exactly is the problem?

Example: “The mobile is not charging.”

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D – Define the Goals

Decide what result you want to achieve.

State the desired outcome clearly.

The goal should tell us what successful results look like.

Ask: What do we want to achieve?

Example: “The mobile should charge properly.”

Remember: D defines the goal; it does not select the solution.

E – Explore Possible Solutions

Generate and consider different ways to solve the problem.

Think of multiple possible solutions.

Compare alternatives instead of choosing the first idea.

Ask: What different solutions can we try?

Example: Try another cable, another charger, another socket, or check the charging port.

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A – Act on the Best Solution

Choose the most suitable option and implement it.

Evaluate the possible solutions.

Select the most appropriate solution.

Put the selected solution into action.

Example: Testing shows the cable is damaged → use a new cable.

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L – Look Back and Learn

Check the result and learn from the experience.

Check whether the solution actually solved the problem.

Ask: Did it work? What can we improve next time?

If it did not work, revisit the problem and try another solution.

Example: The mobile starts charging → solution successful.

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Complete Example: Mobile Not Charging ■

I – Identify: Mobile is not charging; investigate the possible cause.

D – Define: Goal is to make the mobile charge properly.

E – Explore: Try another cable, charger, socket, or check the port.

A – Act: Choose the best option; replace the damaged cable.

L – Look Back: Check whether charging works and note what was learned.

IDEAL Model vs Characteristics of an Effective Problem Solver

Characteristics = qualities / abilities needed for effective problem solving.

IDEAL = steps / process followed to solve a particular problem.

Example characteristic: Analytical thinking → ability to examine causes and information.

Example IDEAL step: E – Explore Possible Solutions → generate and consider alternatives.

Easy rule: “Characteristics = what is needed; IDEAL = what we do.”

Quick Classroom Recap

I → What is the problem?

D → What result do we want?

E → What possible solutions are available?

A → Which solution should we implement?

L → Did it work, and what did we learn?

IDEAL = Identify → Define → Explore → Act → Look Back

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Class Activity

Problem: "Students are frequently submitting assignments late."

Ask students to apply IDEAL:

I – Identify the actual problem

D – Define the desired goal

E – List 3–4 possible solutions

A – Select and implement the best solution

L – Check the result and suggest one improvement